The Impact of Teachers

Fist Period by Kevin M. Derrig & No Writer Left Behind by Livia Kent

half way through first period
dust accumulated on the sweaty palm of my
raised hand
must be a centimeter thick by now
as the chicken-legged teacher goes around the
room
defacing students' homework from last night
with red pen graffiti
that focuses more on missed commas than the
content of the sentences
he finally decides to acknowledge me
"Mr. Derrig, why do I have a feeling that this is
another one of your dumb
comments. You constantly waste my time. Why
don't you just drop out or something?"

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why don't I just drop out
why don't I just drop out!

INTRODUCTION

First Period by Kevin M. Derring

and it was at that moment that all statistics
began to make sense to me
statistics of children whose mouths water more
for the many taste of
society corner slanged penicillins
than the cardboard textures of diplomas
with pipes more important to fill
than class requirements
statistics of classes cut
to avoid battlefields full of aggravated shrapnel
from teachers with exploding tempers
teachers with magnifying glasses at the end
pointers
who feed off the brightness of surrounding
students

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to singe holes in the esteems of those who need
just a little more help
than
others
I wanted to turn my shot-down hand into a fist
I wanted to hit him 'til he was incapable of
speaking anymore
but I didn't want to become another number in
overflowing manila folders
of children arrested in school
and we wonder why a gun seems to fit perfectly
in the hands of this generation's adolescents
ladies and gentlemen
I'm writing this poem to highlight that which has
been stuck like gum
underneath wobbly desks
free from parental eyes
only to mess the hand of those who have to sit
there
I'm writing this poem to speak for all the rows of
children before me

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who remained voiceless in the cracks of school
and its soundproof textbooks
I'm writing this poem for all the children who
have not yet been named
the ones that will one day have to fill these rows
I've been struggling in
only to enter classrooms where they'll be shot
down for what they feel
ladies and gentlemen
the future of America is being crushed between
the molars
of power-hungry tyrants who think class rooms
are boot camps
and if we have any teachers in the audience
I urge you to understand that the hand you grab
the chalk with
the hand you grab those red pens with
the voices you speak with
are oversized chisels
and you must proceed to teach with caution
for what you say and what you do is written in

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stone

and if you chisel too hard these minds can crack

"So what don't you understand now, Mr. Derrig?"

I just wanted to know if I could go to the bathroom

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kevin M. Derrig
Book: The Spoken Word Revolution: Slam, Hip Hop & the Poetry of a New Generation
ISBN: 978-1402202469
Publisher: Sourcebooks, Incorporated
Date (Month/Year): March 2005

AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier

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TRANSITION

Teachers should never minimize the role they play in influencing students' lives. Hopefully, unlike Kevin Derrig's experience, that role will be positive, possessing the qualities of a "charismatic adult" who not only touches students' minds but also their spirits -- the way they see and feel about themselves for the rest of their lives. Such influence is truly a rare privilege that should be prized and nurtured. For every dream-stifling, spirit-crushing teacher there are many others who breathe life into the dreams of student. There are teachers like Livia Kent . . . . who nurtures, inspires and sincerely believes that there will be No Writer Left Behind.

I teach poetry at an inner-city middle school where my students complain about having to fill a blank page with meaningful words. But I watch as they struggle to find similes that adequately reflect their personalities and experiences. I watch as they start to hone their poetic voices, not for accolades, but because they've recognized that through hyperbole and personification and synethesia-all those big words they refuse to remember-they can genuinely disclose their feelings to a back stabbing peer, a preoccupied parent, or even a murdered cousin whose pull once seemed

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greater that the sun's.

For one of the first classes I taught I played Chopin and asked my students to transcribe the sounds into images. After the inevitable objections-why can't we hear the radio, classical music sucks-I finally persuaded them to close their eyes and listen. A resulting poem, written by the one girl who had perfected the art of eye-rolling, began with a visceral description of a frightened woman running through a forest. She loses a shoe but can't stop to pick it up. She is tired and out of breath and in the end turns out to be running from herself. While I had commended myself earlier on pointing out the ties between the poetry my students shunned and the hip-hop they loved, it was ultimately the inner acuity of this girl's poem that convinced my students writing was worthy of their time.

Of course the beginning of every year brings new students who tell me they neither read nor write for pleasure. But I remind myself that since the school librarian was fired to minimize expenses, the authors they may have been tempted to pick up and emulate are

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now inaccessible. So I drag them, kicking and screaming, over the sculpted language of Nikki Giovanni's "Cotton Candy on a Rainy Day." And I tell them, as they rustle their concealed snacks, that I forgive their prickly resistance because I know what it's like be starved. Recently, one girl took issue with my comment.

"My grandma buys food and cooks for me every day. You can't come here and tell us we don't get fed."

I explained that it was poetic malnourishment I had been referring to

The United Nations views "literacy as freedom." Yet in a school where children can read and write but are reluctant to do either, what turns out to be their key to freedom is literary expression, which must sometimes be forced down their throats.

For an entire year I taught a seventh-grade boy whose writing averaged a half a sentence per two-hour class. Most of the time he spent chewing on his cuticles and making sure his baseball cap sat sufficiently crooked on his head. One day, after an exercise inspired by Pablo Neruda's collection, The Book of Questions, this boy

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raised his hand for the first time that year. To my surprise he wanted to share what he had written.

"But, Steve," I whispered, "you've only written one line."

He shrugged. The title of his poem was a question I had posed earlier, a question I doubted any of my writers would dare to tackle. "What is Eternity?" he read. And his answer was as follows: "Eternity is an abandoned house that is never vacant, a black smudge that is always clean." The class erupted in applause, and this boy's shy recitation of a one-line poem, the smile on his otherwise stern little face-this moment will remain the reason I cannot join the teachers who lament the superficiality of today's youth.

Throughout the ages there have always been troublemakers, reticent boys, heartbroken girls, angry teenagers lost in a sense of isolation. What we as teachers must remember is that although these children may not always be churning out high-minded grammatically correct prose, as long as they are writing creatively, they are groping their way, word by word, out

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of the dim and complex years of adolescence. Hopefully, as they become adults, they will carry with them an insatiable hunger for great literature-writing they can taste and feel and tamp into the souls of the next turbulent generation.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Livia Kent
Book: The Bookwoman, v. 67, no. 3
ISBN: N/A
Publisher: Women's National Book Association
Date (Month/Year): Fall 2004

****The Bookwoman — The Official Publication of the Women's National Book Association (published, 4x per year; print circulation, 13,500)***

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